

[Reviewer: scorkery-762-655265]

Rating: 9/10

Review: One scene that has stuck with me for 44 yrs... Just a little side note, an observation from one scene that has stayed with me since I first saw this movie nearly 45 yrs ago. It's the middle of the movie when Travis is going thru his metamorphosis from simple-minded taxi driver to full on psychotic protector/vigilante; the iconic "You talkin' to me?" scene. He's in his drab apartment watching American Bandstand and as Jackson Browne's achingly beautiful song "Late For The Sky" plays, the AB dancers sway slowly to the beat, holding each other close...teenagers in love having a tender moment. Travis' face shows how desperately lonely he is; how he's probably never even danced with a girl in his life, much less had a normal relationship with one and how he needs to make a love connection with the Jodie Foster or Cybill Shepherd characters in a most sensational way. To me, a crystallizing scene that moves the story along to its' inevitable shocking end.

[Reviewer: BA Harrison]

Rating: 7/10

Review: A classy character study of a disturbed individual—but what is the point? Insomniac Vietnam veteran Travis Bickle (Robert De Niro) takes a job driving a New York taxi cab, becomes obsessed with beautiful political campaigner Betsy (Cybill Shepherd), who gives him the cold shoulder after he tries to take her to a skin flick on a date. Bickle then becomes obsessed with underage hooker Iris (Jodie Foster), buys lots of guns, and goes trigger happy on her pimp (Harvey Keitel).

As a fan of gritty 70s movie-making, I find it hard to believe that, until now, I hadn't seen Martin Scorsese's Taxi Driver; I think perhaps the problem was that, having heard so many good things about the film, I didn't want to risk disappointment. Unfortunately, that's precisely what I felt when I finally got around to watching the film.

It's not that it's a bad movie by any stretch of the imagination-on the contrary, it's a skilfully assembled character study of a self-destructive loose cannon that boasts excellent cinematography, great music, and superb performances-BUT in the end it just didn't grab me as much as I would have liked. The story progresses very slowly, which in itself isn't a massive issue for me, but the payoff simply isn't as satisfying as I felt it needed to be given all that has gone before.

After all of his stalking, inane rambling and meticulous planning, Travis Bickle's rampage is over in a flash, after which he is proclaimed a hero and freed to roam the streets once more (unless you prescribe to the theory that everything after the shootout is in Bickle's mind as he slowly bleeds to death). Perhaps Scorsese's point

was to show us just how easy it is for a dangerous loony like Bickle to be overlooked by society until its too late-but it sure felt like a letdown to me.

6.5 out of 10, rounded up to 7 for Keitel's hair.

[Reviewer: PyroSikTh]

Rating: 7/10

Review: Not Quite Sure on the Acclaim Taxi Driver, if you weren't aware, follows a New York City taxi driver called Travis Bickle as he descends into a state of masculine madness. Along the way he courts Betsy, a member of a local campaign for a presidential candidate, continuously runs into Iris, an underage prostitute, sits on the outside of his cab-driving colleagues, and has his worldview shaped by the men and women he ferries all over the city. Spoilers; it's not a very healthy worldview at all. Taking on the night shift leaves him with a darkened view of a world run by pimps, junkies, thieves, and murderers. He suffers crippling insomnia which leaves him either alone in his apartment fantasising about the man he wants to be, or huddled in a porno theatre, the irony completely lost on him.

Taxi Driver is, at its core, a character study of a lonely and unstable young man. Coupled with its 70s style of filmmaking, this results in it being a super slow movie, far slower than I anticipated. In truth, this is a big reason why it was so hard for me to really get into. Half the movie is spent watching the debacle between Travis and Betsy play out, as he stalks her, awkwardly asks her out, promptly loses her after taking her to watch a porno on their first date (an act so seeped in Travis' own disillusion that it's painful to watch), and desperately trying to contact her to get a second chance. The function of all of this is essential, painting up not only how socially awkward and disconnected Travis is, but also really hammering in his loneliness, as the final straw that causes him to snap. Problem is, as I mentioned, this takes up half the movie. It's a catalyst to his descent into madness and the crippling loneliness he endures, but it doesn't portray either of things directly. If he had just taken her to a normal movie theatre or for an innocent dinner, he probably would've won her heart and enjoyed a fruitful relationship that helped him turn his life around. But this movie isn't so much about what could've been, and for the catalyst to take up so much screentime just slows the pacing of the movie right down. It also takes remarkably too long for Iris to even be introduced, and once she is she disappears again for large portions of the movie (likewise, Betsy is almost completely absent after the breakup). I can certainly get behind Travis becoming obsessed with someone he sees in quick, short bursts, but when he only shows that obsession when she's physically there before him, it results in her presence being almost entirely diminished in between.

Of course I fully recognise that both those points are about characters that this movie strictly isn't about. Betsy and Iris are ultimately just plot devices put in there to drive Travis' character and giving him the motivation to do whatever he chooses to do as the movie goes along. His anger eventually reaches a boiling point, and his first target is Senator Palantine, the presidential candidate Betsy works for, if for no other reason than getting back at Betsy. However he's discouraged at the last minute and instead points his anger as the trio of pimps Iris works for. One thing I did really like about this movie was the juxtaposition between those two choices. Travis needs to take his anger out on someone, and he's sick of the "filth" he sees lining the streets every night, and takes it upon himself to clean it up. If he had assassinated Palantine as he originally intended, he'd have been prosecuted as a villain with a political agenda, despite being horrifically naïve of the politics around him. Instead he's hailed as a hero for taking out delinquents and criminals. And this is where the film's biggest commentary on society as a whole comes in. To him, both Palantine and the criminals represent the same issues, but because he took out his anger on the undesirables of the city, he ends up celebrated. The local newspapers have no problems in branding this unstable, unhinged vigilante as a hero.

The film becomes a direct mockery of the hero complex. Violent, angry men are praised for cleaning up the world and saving the damsel because what they do is ultimately seen as good, when really they're just deranged sociopaths who are unable to express themselves any other way. This is all fantastic, but this late in my life it's nothing new. I guarantee I'd have felt differently back in 1976, and no doubt that's why it's earned as much acclaim as it has. But now, today, I've seen this story a hundred times. I've seen this examination of the hero complex a hundred times. I've seen the anti-hero myth torn apart and put back together so many times I don't even know what's being clever or just riffing off other stories any more. While watching *Taxi Driver*, I instantly saw all manner of other characters in Travis Bickle, from Batman or Joker, to Punisher or Rorschach, from American Psycho to Nightcrawler or *You Were Never Really Here*. So ultimately the question boils down to which ones did it better? And honestly *Taxi Driver* doesn't feature all that high up for me. Just because it was the first doesn't mean it's the best.

Don't get me wrong, I'm not saying *Taxi Driver* doesn't deserve the acclaim it continues to receive. I didn't like how slow and somewhat badly paced it was, nor did I like Bernard Herrman's score which feels misplaced and repetitive, but it's not a bad movie by any means. The dialogue is real and relatable, De Niro's performance is next level stuff, the camera work is often creative and interesting, creating imagery that'll stick with you forever, and no matter how many times the general story of a lonely, angry, unstable individual going on violent killing sprees and carefully toeing the line between hero and villain has been told, it'll never be one to ignore. I give *Taxi Driver* a decent 7/10. Go ahead and tell me why I'm wrong, or what I've clearly missed,

because I'm nearly tearing my hair out trying to figure out why this movie is quite as highly regarded as it is.

[Reviewer: andrew7]

Rating: 10/10

Review: **Disturbing, powerful, relevant, important**

. A towering classic of American cinematic power. Martin Scorsese teams up with one of the most intense actors of that time to create a masterpiece of urban alienation. Paul Schrader's magnificent script paints a portrait of loneliness in the largest city of the world. Travis never once enters into a meaningful relationship with any character anywhere in the film. He is the most hopelessly alone person I've ever encountered on film.

He is alone with his thoughts, and his thoughts are dark ones. The film fools you on a first viewing. Is Travis an endearing eccentric? Sure, he's odd, but he's so polite, and he's got a quirky sense of humor. His affection for Betsy is actually rather endearing. But on a second view, you see it for what it is. The audience comes to see Travis's psychosis gradually, but there's actually far less development than one might think. When he talks about cleaning up the city, the repeat viewer knows he doesn't mean some sort of Giuliani-facelift. This is less a film about a character in development as it is a kind of snapshot. To be sure, it takes the stimulus to provoke the response, but does that imply some kind of central change in the character?

Tremendous supporting roles are brought to life through vivid performances by Keitel and Foster especially. Shepard's character, Betsy, is little more than a foil to highlight Travis's utter alienation from society, but she is still impeccably portrayed. With only two scenes that don't center on Travis, it is unavoidably De Niro's show. The life with which the supporting cast imbues their characters is a credit to themselves, and to the director's willingness to let the film develop from the intersection of diverse ideas and approaches. What would the plot lose by eliminating the Albert Brooks character (Tom)? Nothing at all. He makes almost no impact on Travis's life, which is where the plot lives. But his inclusion makes the film as a whole much richer and fuller.

As a piece of American cinema history, this film will live forever. But far more important than that, this film will survive as a universal, ever-relevant examination of the workings of the alienated mind. The story doesn't end when the credits roll. We know Travis will snap again. But the story doesn't end with Travis either. It continues today in the cities and in the schools. The film is about the brutal power of the disaffected mind.

This film didn't cause the incidents in Colombine, or Hawaii, or Seattle, or wherever you care to look, even with all of its disturbing images of violence. It didn't cause those things. It predicted them.